

Breast cancer in India presents a full decade earlier than in the West. In Delhi NCR the peak age of incidence is around 45 — which means that if we want to catch disease early, awareness has to begin in a woman's mid-thirties.

That creates a real problem. Mammography-based screening only becomes reliable from about 40–45, because younger breasts are denser and the yield is poor. So for women in their thirties, we have no organised screening programme to offer. What we have is a woman's own knowledge of her body.

This is not a soft argument. The Mumbai cluster-randomised trial — over 150,000 women followed for 20 years — showed that physical examination-based screening significantly down staged breast cancer at diagnosis, with a nearly 30% reduction in mortality in women over 50. Stage matters enormously, and detection at Stage II rather than Stage III or IV changes what we can offer a patient.

The truth in Indian practice is that most breast cancers are found by the woman herself. The gap is rarely that she failed to notice something — it is the delay between noticing and acting. Anything that makes self-examination a regular habit, and shortens that delay, is worth supporting.

Which is why the app developed by this young woman to guide and encourage self-examination is such a commendable effort. It puts the tool in the hands of exactly the group our screening infrastructure does not reach. I congratulate her warmly, and I hope it finds the reach it deserves.

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